



The Fool's Court

A trick-taking game of promises, for four players

FOUR PLAYERS

60 CARDS · 15 WHISPERS

FIRST TO 50 FAVOUR

1 Overview

Four nobles compete for the ear of the monarch over a series of **sessions**. At the start of each session every player privately promises how many **audiences** they will win, and then plays to reach that number exactly.

Favour is awarded for precision rather than for ambition. Winning more audiences than you promised is penalised just as surely as winning fewer, so the difficulty of the game lies in judging a hand accurately and then steering it to land on the number. The first player past **50 favour** wins the season.

A promise is a **pledge**. A trick is an **audience**. The trump suit is the **sway**. Points are **favour**. The dealer is the **steward**.

2 The deck

Sixty cards: four kinds of agent, each ranked **1 to 15**. Rank 15 is the most influential and rank 1 the least.

AGENT	MARK	PROMISES
Fool	👑 cap and bells	0
Merchant	⚖️ the balance	1
Lover	🌹 the rose	2
Assassin	⚔️ the blade	3

An agent's **kind** decides what it is worth when sent out on an errand (4). An agent's **rank** decides whether it wins an audience (5). The two are used at different times and never interact.

3 Seating and the deal

Four players sit in a fixed order. Play and the deal both proceed **clockwise**, which is to say to the left.

- One player is the **steward** for the session and deals **15 cards** to each player, exhausting the deck.
- Each player makes a pledge (4).
- Eleven audiences are played out (5).
- Favour is scored, and the sway for the next session is set (6 and 7).
- The stewardship passes one seat to the left, and a new session begins.

4 Making a pledge

4.1 Before any card is played, each player selects **four cards** from their hand and places them face down in front of them. These are that player's **errands**.

4.2 A player's **pledge** is the sum of the errand values of the four cards sent, by kind. **Rank is disregarded entirely**: a Fool of 15 promises exactly as little as a Fool of 1.

4.3 Errands remain face down and **out of play** for the rest of the session. Eleven cards therefore remain in each hand, and **eleven audiences** are contested.

4.4 A pledge is **not capped**. Four Assassins constitute a pledge of twelve, which exceeds the eleven audiences available and cannot be kept under any circumstances. Nothing in the rules forbids it.

4.5 All errands are revealed simultaneously when the session ends. Until then, no player knows another's pledge, nor which cards have left another's hand.

The cards that make your promise are the cards you no longer get to play. Promising a great deal costs you Assassins; promising nothing is cheap only if your Fools were worthless to begin with. This tension is the heart of the game.

5 Playing the session

5.1 The player to the steward's left **opens** the first audience by playing any card from their hand, including one of the ruling kind.

5.2 Play continues clockwise. Each player in turn must **answer in kind** – play a card of the same kind as the one that opened the audience – if they hold one. A player holding none may play any card at all.

5.3 The audience is won by the **highest-ranked card of the kind that opened it**, unless one or more cards of the **ruling kind** (7) were played, in which case the highest-ranked of those wins instead.

5.4 A card of neither the opening kind nor the ruling kind can never win an audience, whatever its rank.

5.5 The winner of an audience opens the next. Eleven audiences are played, exhausting every hand.

6 Winning favour

At the end of the session each player compares the audiences they won against the pledge they made.

RESULT	FAVOUR
Pledge kept exactly	2 for every audience won
Pledge missed, high or low	1 for every audience won, less 2 for every audience off the pledge
Pledged nothing, won nothing	5
Pledged nothing, won audiences	–5 for the first, –2 for each after
Pledged 4, won 4	+8
Pledged 5, won 4	+2
Pledged 3, won 6	0
Pledged 2, won 0	–4
Pledged 0, won 0	+5
Pledged 0, won 3	–9
Pledged 12, won 11	+9

Because being wrong costs 2 favour per audience in either direction, there is no advantage in deliberately under-promising and overshooting. The only good outcome is the exact one. A pledge of twelve cannot be kept: eleven promised and delivered would have paid 22.

7 Who holds sway

One kind of agent may **hold sway** for a session, outranking every other kind when audiences are decided (5.3). Sway is not chosen by any player. It is set by how the *previous* session went.

The first session of a season is always played at **No Sway**, where no kind outranks any other. After that, sway passes according to how many of the four nobles kept their pledge **exactly** in the session before.

PLEDGES KEPT	SWAY NEXT SESSION
0	 Fools
1	 Merchants
2	 Lovers
3	 Assassins
4	No Sway

The ladder runs from the humblest agent to the most dangerous. When the whole court fails, the Fool rules it; when the whole court succeeds, nobody does. Because sway is public knowledge before pledges are made, every player knows which kind is dangerous while deciding what to promise.

8 The Whispers OPTIONAL

The Whispers are an optional component. A season played without them is a complete game.

8.1 Before each session the monarch has a private word with every noble. Each player receives one **Whisper**, dealt face down from the fifteen below. No two players receive the same Whisper in a session.

8.2 A Whisper alters how that player's favour is counted, or restricts which agents they may send out on errands, or both. It is **private**, and is revealed only when the session ends, alongside the errands.

8.3 Where a Whisper restricts errands, the restriction is binding. If a player's hand makes it **impossible to obey** — being required to send an Assassin while holding none, for instance — the demand is **waived** for that session and the player pledges freely.

8.4 A Whisper never changes the rules of play in section 5. Every player answers in kind, and audiences are won exactly as described, whatever their Whisper says.

WHAT YOU MAY SEND

Blackmailed. At least one Assassin must go out. Keep your pledge for +5.

Sworn to Silence. No Assassin may go out. Keep your pledge for +3.

The Smitten. No Lover may go out. Keep your pledge for +3.

The Audited. Send two Merchants and two Fools, which pledges exactly 2. Keep it for +4.

HOW YOUR RESULT IS SCORED

The Debtor. A kept pledge of 2 or fewer earns nothing; keep 3 or more for +3.

All or Nothing. Keep your pledge for double favour. Break it and lose 3, whatever else you did.

The Cautious Clerk. You cannot lose favour this session, nor gain more than 6.

HOW YOU COMPARE TO THE TABLE

The Bold. +5 if your pledge is the highest at the table, outright.

The Meek. -4 if your pledge is the lowest or tied for lowest. Keep it for +4.

The Kingmaker. Keep your pledge and take +2 for every other noble who broke theirs.

The Favourite. +6 if you win more audiences than any other noble, outright.

The Wallflower. +6 if you win fewer audiences than any other noble, outright.

HOW YOU WIN AUDIENCES

Sworn to the Fool. +3 favour for every audience you take with a Fool.

INVERSION AND MISDIRECTION

The Contrarian. Your pledge counts the audiences you will NOT win. Keep it for +2.

The Understudy. You are scored against the pledge of the noble on your left, not your own. Take +3 for the trouble, and +5 more if you match it.

The Whispers are what make the table worth watching. A rival who pledges strangely, or who ducks an audience they could plainly have won, is telling you something about the word they were given.

9 Winning the season

9.1 The season ends at the conclusion of the session in which any player reaches **50 favour** or more.

9.2 The player with the highest total wins. A total of 51 beats a total of 50; reaching the target first confers nothing by itself.

9.3 Should two or more players finish level on favour, the season goes to whichever of them, in order: won more favour in the final session; made the higher pledge in the final session; sent out the four errands of the higher combined rank in the final session.

10 Summary of play

1. The steward deals 15 cards to each of the four players.
2. Each player sends four agents out on errands, face down. Their kinds are that player's pledge; their ranks are irrelevant.
3. If Whispers are in use, each player has already been given one, face down.
4. The player to the steward's left opens the first of eleven audiences.
5. Players answer in kind where they can. The highest of the opening kind takes the audience, unless the ruling kind was played, in which case the highest of those does.
6. The winner of each audience opens the next.
7. Errands and Whispers are revealed. Favour is scored on the exactness of each pledge.
8. The number of pledges kept sets the sway for the next session.
9. The stewardship passes one seat to the left.
10. Play continues until a player passes 50 favour.

Sixty agents, four sent away unseen, eleven audiences to divide between four nobles who have each already said how many they will take. Everything after the deal is arithmetic and nerve.